

METHODOLOGY

How the ranking was done

The INDIA TODAY annual survey of academic excellence is now in its 13th year. For 2009, INDIA TODAY commissioned The Nielsen Company, a leading market research group, to conduct a comprehensive survey of colleges and institutions offering arts, science, commerce, law, engineering and medicine to identify the best colleges in their respective fields. While in arts, commerce and science, colleges in 12 major cities—Ahmedabad, Bangalore, Chandigarh, Chennai, Delhi, Hyderabad, Jaipur, Kochi, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai and Pune—were chosen for the survey, the streams of law, engineering and medicine were not confined to the cities mentioned. To determine the ranking, a Nielsen team comprising Umesh Jha, Maria Rani Tirkey and Sugandha Shejvalker, worked on a formula based on a perception score (from an opinion poll conducted among academic experts) and an objective score (factual data furnished by colleges).

The process began late last year when research was conducted to generate the list of colleges for the survey and various secondary data sources like the Internet, published reports and the Association of Indian Universities Handbook were used. This year it was decided not to consider faculties of universities except in the law stream for ranking. A comprehensive list of more than 1,500 colleges was drawn up. To calculate the final score, nearly 1,000 experts at the level of principals, heads of department and deans in 12 cities were interviewed for the various stages (*see below*) in the months of January, February and March this year.

After comprehensive lists of each of the streams were compiled, awareness regarding various institutes was captured from experts from each of the streams who were then asked to distribute 100 points across five vital parameters—Reputation of Colleges, Quality of Academic Inputs, Student Care, Infrastructure and Job Prospects. Each of these five criteria were assigned a weight-based on the importance given by the experts. Thus the most important parameter got the most weight and the least, the lowest. All the experts were asked to rate the colleges of their respective fields on these key parameters. To eliminate bias, the experts were not allowed to rate their own colleges. The overall perceptual score of a college was calculated on the basis of the rating given by experts on the above-mentioned five criteria weighted by their importance.

Like the 2008 survey, for arts, science and commerce,



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH. Model Karan Raj Sharma. Courtesy Gitz Modeling Agency. Location Courtesy Miranda House, Delhi

experts were asked to rate the colleges only for their city while for engineering, medicine and law, they were asked to rate colleges for their respective zones (east, west, north and south). On the basis of the output from this step, a list was obtained of colleges to be evaluated at a national level. In the next step, academic experts rated the colleges on the list in a national perspective. In addition, the experts were also shown the city list and asked to rate the colleges of their city. It provided a fairer chance to each